



Boy WHO LOVED WORDS



TER

RON! SCHOTTER

GISELLE potter

\$16.95 U.S.

\$23.95 Can.

Ages 4-8

SPRINKLE

Words. Selig loves everything about them—the way they taste on his tongue (*tantalizing*), the sound they whisper in his ears (*tintinnabulating!*), and—most of all—the way they stir his heart. And he collects them *voraciously*, the way others collect stamps or seashells.

But what to do with so many *luscious* words? Surrounded by doubters, Selig journeys forth and discovers that there is always someone—a poet, a baker, maybe even YOU—searching for the perfect word that he can provide.

This enchanting tall tale from Roni Schotter—*chockablock* with whimsical illustrations by Giselle Potter—celebrates language, the gift and *gusto* of words, and one boy's larger-than-life *passion* to share them.

ns

ning

LEM

OLO

y

H

ATED

g

ndy

exultant

COBBLED

Nod

afloat

CRUNCHY

SLUMBER

adoration

CRISPY

stimulate

percolated

SOLO

RHAPSODY

ODDBALL

melted

sizzling

passion

myth

WINDMILL

scrupulous

agreement

Mysterious

snug

stirring

liveliness

SPRINKLE SCHOTTER
Schotter, Roni
The boy who loved words

31111025715465 BEL-TIB

distinctive

giggle

luscious

Precision

shambling

SNUG

Zesty

LEMON

dusk

LOZENGE

yellow

fruit

proclaimed

Spluttering

SPARKLING

sway

Fuss

pulsing

HUBBUB

encountered

Mama

flippant

honey

ambling

shuffling

mellifluous

exhilarating

nuzzle

RELIABLE

harmony

AMPHORA

word

tantalizing

GLORIOUS

TODDLE

plucked

Lyre

hidden

For Richard and Jesse,
wondrous wordsmiths/merry muses —R.S.

For Pia, collecting and saying new words every day —G.P.

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an imprint of Random House Children's Books, a division of Random House, Inc., New York.

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Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Schotter, Roni.

The boy who loved words / Roni Schotter ; illustrated by Giselle Potter. — 1st ed.
p. cm.

Summary: Selig, who loves words and copies them on pieces of paper that he carries with him,
goes on a trip to discover his purpose.

ISBN 0-375-83601-2 (alk. paper) — ISBN 0-375-93601-7 (lib. bdg.)

[1. Language and languages—Fiction. 2. Self-actualization (Psychology)—Fiction.]

I. Potter, Giselle, ill. II. Title.

PZ7.S3763 Boy 2006

[E]—dc22

2005010850

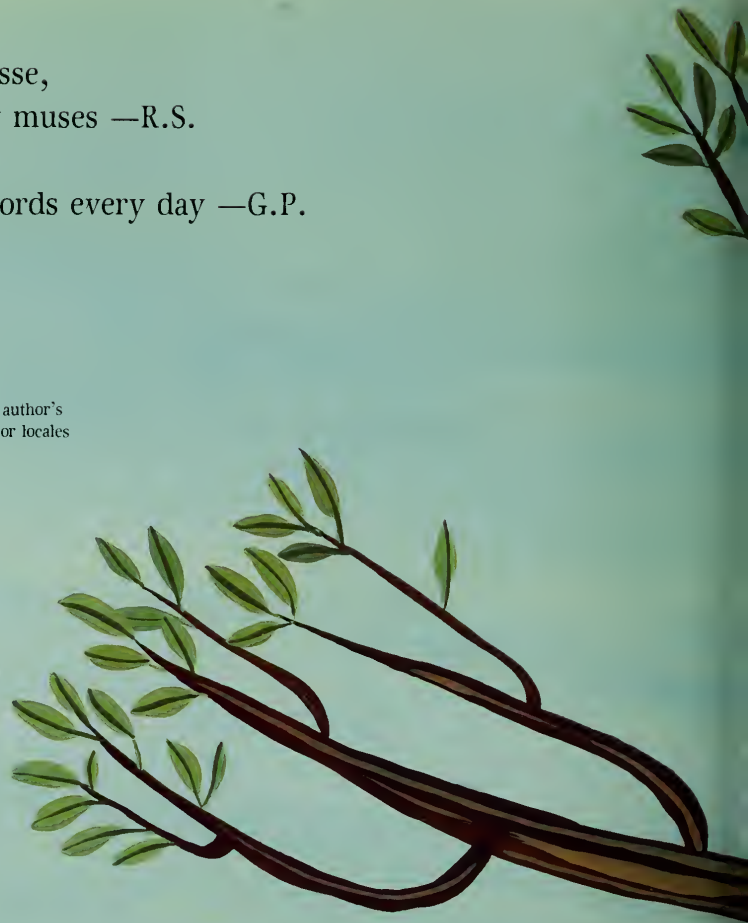
The text for this book is set in Geislerifa.

The illustrations for this book are rendered in pencil, ink, gouache, gesso, watercolor, and collage.

MANUFACTURED IN CHINA

10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

First Edition



A NOTE ABOUT WORDSWORTH'S WONDERFUL WORDS

On the back endpapers are some of Wordsworth's wonderful words—words he loves the sound,
the taste, and the meaning of. Some of them may be new to you. If you too find them wonderful,
perhaps they may become your favorites as well. Who can tell? Maybe you'll start your
own collection of wonderful words.—R.S.



The

Boy

WHO

LOVED

WORDS

BY

RONI SCHOTTER

PICTURES

by

GISELLE

potter

SCHWARTZ & WADE BOOKS

NEW YORK

There are, in this world, people who are born collectors. Some collect shells or stones. Others, feathers. Some have even been known to collect tiny teaspoons. Such a one was Selig. *He* was a collector of words.

Selig loved everything about words—the sound of them in his ears (*tintinnabulating!*), the taste of them on his tongue (*tantalizing!*), the thought of them when they *percolated* in his brain (*stirring!*), and, most especially, the feel of them when they moved his heart (*Mama!*).

Whenever Selig heard a word he liked, he'd shout it loud, *jot* it down on a slip of paper, then stuff it into his pocket to save. Such a collector! Selig's pockets positively brimmed with words. He stuffed new ones inside his shirt, down his socks, up his sleeves, under his hat.

phenomenon

POROUS

smooth

Luxury

Electric

BEAUTIFUL

RARE

Obligation

fragrant

EARNEST,

melted

Tantalize

enchanted

comfortable

GENTLE

cheerful

Compliment

GLEAMING-

genuine

stirring

joy

whisper

continuous





While other children busied themselves with bats, nets, and all manner of balls, Selig stayed on the outskirts, always on the periphery—watching and collecting delicious words.

shuffle

deliberate

precision

SW



bubbling

dribble

scoop

swoop

flying

hurdle

Hit



His father, a practical man who sold sturdy shoes for a living, wondered what good could possibly come from a son with such a strange *predilection*.

His mother, a large, lovely woman from the Old Country, worried—could her beautiful boy find happiness? Waving her arms in the air, she was a *windmill* of worry.

A woman with dark hair, wearing an orange dress with a white floral pattern and a full orange skirt, stands in a room. She has a worried expression and is waving her arms. The room has a green wall and a window with white frames. The floor is yellow. Various words and papers are floating around her, including "WINDMILL", "rolled", "quiet", "Snooz", "Dust", "GENUINE", "vibrant", "NOSTALGIA", "Luxurious", "Beautiful", "HOME", "melting", "noax", "precious", "mystify", "brilliant", "LA", "TO", "MISS", "FROM", "Dust", "GENUINE", "vibrant", "NOSTALGIA", "Luxurious", "Beautiful", "HOME", "melting", "noax", "precious", "mystify", "brilliant", "LA", "TO", "MISS", "FROM".



ODDBALL

insulting

buzz

alone.

As time went on, people began calling Selig by a new name: Wordsworth. “Hey, Wordsworth,” kids would *giggle*. “Here’s a word for your collection—*oddball*!”

“*Oddball*!” Selig repeated. The silly-sounding word should have made him giggle, but instead it made him lonely.





cunning

giggle

One night, Selig had a dream. . . . Alone, in front of an unusual *emporium*, he encountered an oversized *amphora*. Curious, Selig gave it a tap. *Swooooooosh!* Out popped a *swarthy*, *swirling* man. “*Djinn!*” Selig exclaimed, then, “Genie!” he shouted, enjoying the tang of tasty new words.

“Vhat you vant?” the Genie asked. “A vish?”

Such strange and *savory* sounds! Such an offer! At a loss for words, Selig suddenly knew his *vish*—it was for an answer. “Is it true, am I really . . . an . . . *oddball*?”

“Oddball? Feh! You are Voidsvoith, a lover of voids. Already you have vhat people search their whole life for—an enthusiasm, a *passion*. Vhat you need now is a poipose, a mission.” Then, without a word of warning, the Genie disappeared.

Selig awakened from his dream. . . . *Lickety-split*, he packed a *rucksack* with a pillow and blanket, apples, honey, cream soda, and his entire collection of words. He knew exactly what he had to do. Selig took to the road, determined to find his purpose.





mystical

Genie

glowing

Djinn

passion

DREAM

odd ball

magical

swirl

rugged



On the trail of his purpose, Selig's senses sharpened. He noted the nod and *toddle* of tulips in the wind; the sway and *swagger* of tree branches; how, at evening, the light dimmed to announce the arrival of twilight and stars. *Dusk*, Selig noted, adding that short and enchanting word to his collection.







But in time Selig's step grew heavy. Under the weight of so many words, it was harder and harder to move. He was *shuffling* and *shambling* when he might have been *rambling* and *ambling*. Perhaps what he needed to do was lighten his load. But HOW? Throw words away? Waste them? Impossible! They were far too precious!

Selig was too tired to think. His exhausted brain could imagine but one thing—*slumber*, a splendid word! Sadly, he was too sleepy to write it down.

In front of Selig stood a large and lovely tree. He removed his jacket, stuffed, like his mama's *strudel*, with words. Tenderly, he hung each word on its own separate branch, as if putting it to bed for the night.

With a sip of cream soda and a nibble of honeyed apple, Selig clambered, then curled in a *crook* of the tree. *Snug*, he thought, and fell directly to sleep. Comfortably cradled there, he dreamed of his mama, his mission, and *macaroons*—his favorite cookie.





During the night, a pacing poet, unable to sleep for want of a word, found himself under the same tree, gazing hopelessly at the moon. Night after night, he'd been struggling to find the right words to describe it.



Suddenly, mysteriously, a swirling wind blew up. Four of Selig's words sailed off their branches. Reaching skyward, the distracted poet caught them. Discarding the word *macaroon*, he held tightly to *lozenge*, *lemon*, and *licorice*. "The moon," he wrote in his notebook, growing more and more excited with each word, "melted like a *lemon lozenge* in the *licorice* sky."

"My stars!" the poet shouted, *exultant*. "That's it!"



The following morning Selig awoke to what could only be called a *rhapsody* of birds and words. The poet was reading his newest poem aloud—a poem *chockablock* with Selig's words!

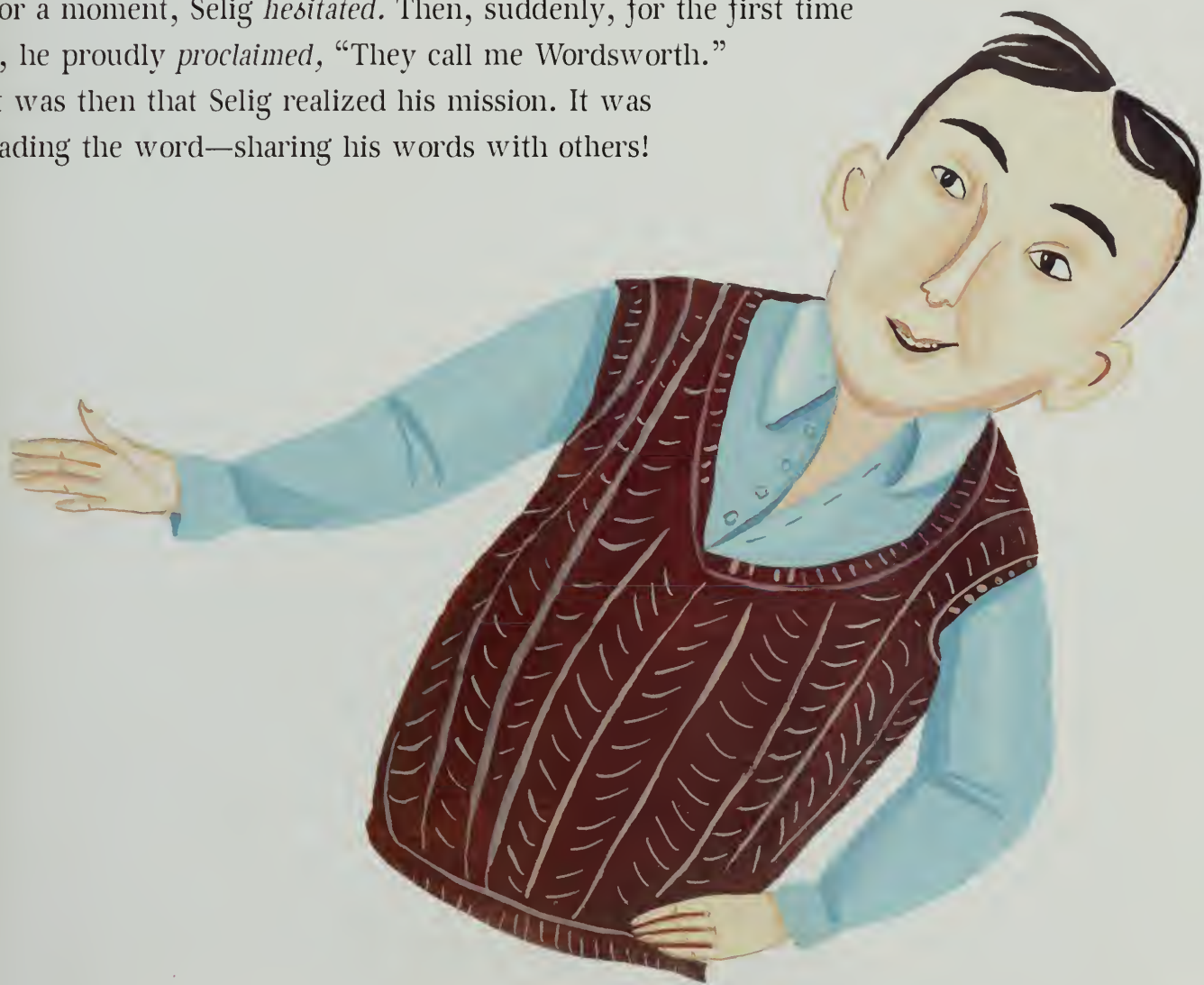


Wiping the sleep crumbs from his eyes, Selig scrambled down the tree and saluted the poet. "Your poem," he told him, "contains some of my favorite words. How beautifully you use them."

"Why, thank you. For once, the words just seemed to come to me. Upon my word! How lucky I am! What, may I ask, is your name? I should like to dedicate my poem to you."

For a moment, Selig *hesitated*. Then, suddenly, for the first time ever, he proudly *proclaimed*, "They call me Wordsworth."

It was then that Selig realized his mission. It was spreading the word—sharing his words with others!



From that day forth, Selig's steps were light and filled with purpose. Ever the collector, he added new words as it pleased him. But now, whenever he felt word-heavy, he discovered the ideal places to *sprinkle*, *disburse*, and *broadcast* them.



In that way, a baker whose pastries had always been ignored found his shop filled with a mob of hungry customers. When the baker's back was turned, Selig, on a macaroon break, had tossed some of his favorite words into the air. *Crispy* and *crunchy* landed next to the crumpets. *Scrumptious* fell against a loaf of pumpernickel. *Luscious* leaned against a layer cake. "Upon my word! How lucky I am!" the baker exclaimed when he turned back and saw his *voracious* new customers.





Neighbors realized they were bickering when the words *fuss*, *hubbub*, and *jibber-jabber* rained down on them . . . and stopped their fighting.



Selig watched them grow still and gaze kindly upon one another after he cast *hush*, *harmony*, and *chum* in their direction.



And so, by word of mouth, the legend began. . . .
“It’s Wordsworth,” people would whisper, when,
suddenly, the right word occurred to them. “HE is
near,” they would nod, knowingly. “Upon my word!
How lucky we are!”



Masterpiece



apologies



Years passed. Selig was a man now, also a *myth*. But while he delighted in his work, he found that, once again, he was lonely. “*Solo*,” he sighed.



One day, after launching the words *limber*, *spry*, and *gusto* toward an aging, unhappy man, Selig heard a sound on the breeze. A single, *pulsing*, marvelous note floated through the air and found its way straight into his heart. "*Mellifluous!*" he exclaimed.

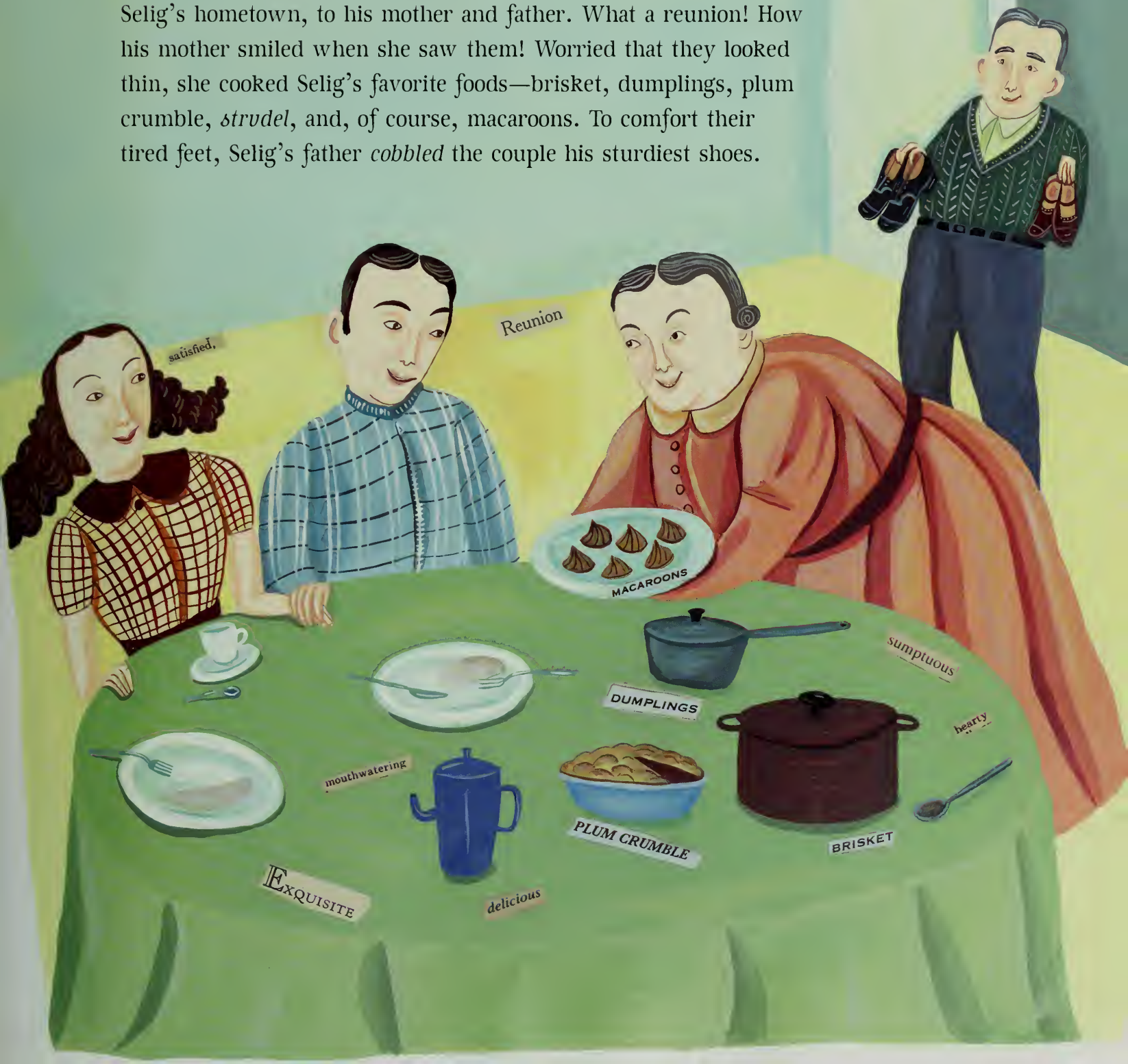




Pursuing that perfect note, Selig found a young woman seated by a lake, playing a lute. Suddenly, his heart was *aflutter*. *Tremulously* he asked, "M-m-may I have a word with you? Wh-wh-what is your name?"

"They call me *Melody*," the woman sang out. The music of her voice, combined with the charm of her words, was, to Selig, the sweetest of all songs.

It was love at first listen. Together, they journeyed back to Selig's hometown, to his mother and father. What a reunion! How his mother smiled when she saw them! Worried that they looked thin, she cooked Selig's favorite foods—brisket, dumplings, plum crumble, *strudel*, and, of course, macaroons. To comfort their tired feet, Selig's father *cobbled* the couple his sturdiest shoes.





Rested and restored, Selig resumed his life's work, joyfully gathering and scattering words on the wind. Since then, word by word, *legions* of lucky people have discovered and delighted in them.

You too may find yourself lucky if, one day, while you are thinking or writing or simply speaking, the perfect word just seems to come to you. If so, you'll know that Selig is near. And on special days, if you feel like humming or suddenly bursting into song, you'll know that Melody is with him. "Upon my word!" you may say. "How lucky I am!"



rolling

strolling

Upon my Word!
How lucky I am!

ample

rare

vibrant

Scenic
LAND

STRUDEL

GUSTO

spry

comfort

ACC

CROOK

GLOSSARY

(IN ALPHABETICAL ORDER)

AFLUTTER—beating quickly

AMBLING—walking easily

AMPHORA—two-handled vase

BROADCAST—to spread widely over an area

CHOCKABLOCK—crowded

CHUM—friend, pal

CLAMBERED—climbed with hands and feet

COBBLED—put together

CRISPY—firm, fresh, easy to crumble

CROOK—a bend or curve

CRUNCHY—crackling fresh

DISBURSE—to distribute, pass out

DJINN—genie, magical person who grants wishes

DUSK—dark part of twilight

EMPORIUM—large store

ENCOUNTERED—met

EXULTANT—full of joy

FUSS—unneeded excitement

GIGGLE—to laugh in a silly way

GUSTO—great enjoyment

HARMONY—a feeling of agreement

HESITATED—waited because of being unsure

HUBBUB—loud, mixed-up noise

HUSH—be quiet

JIBBER-JABBER—nonsense talk

JOT—to write quickly

LEGIONS—large numbers

LEMON—yellow, like the fruit

LICKETY-SPLIT—very fast, right away

LICORICE—black, like the candy

LIMBER—able to bend easily

LOZENGE—small candy, sometimes with medicine in it

LUSCIOUS—rich and delicious

LUTE—a guitar-like musical instrument

COBBLED

SLUMBER

stimulate

SOLO

ODDBALL

ted

WINDMILL

rious

liveliness

SPRINKLE

MACAROON—a chewy cookie, usually almond flavored

MAMA—Mother, Mum, Mommy

MELLIFLUOUS—sweet-sounding

MYTH—a legend or old story about a hero

ODDBALL—strange person

PASSION—strong feeling

PERCOLATED—passed through

PERIPHERY—outside edge

PREDILECTION—fondness for, liking

PROCLAIMED—announced in a fancy way

PULSING—beating like a heart

RAMBLING—taking time to wander

RHAPSODY—expression of enthusiastic feeling

RUCKSACK—knapsack

SAVORY—flavorful, sometimes spicy

SCRUMPTIOUS—delicious

SHAMBLING—walking unsteadily

SHUFFLING—walking without lifting your feet

SLUMBER—s

SNUG—cozy

SOLO—alone

SPRINKLE—t

SPRY—lively

STIRRING—e

STRUDEL—pa

SWAGGER—a proud of

SWARTHY—

SWIRLING—v

TANTALIZING—more

TINTINNABU—bells

TODDLE—a v

TREMULOUS

VORACIOUS—

WINDMILL—driven by

Some of RONI SCHOTTER's favorite words are *cozy*, *snuggle*, *ruckus*, *rutabaga*, and *potato*. She is the author of numerous books for children, including *Nothing Ever Happens on 90th Street*, an NCTE Notable Trade Book in the Language Arts; *F Is for Freedom*, recipient of the Washington Irving Award; *Hanukkah!*, winner of the National Jewish Book Award; *Captain Bob Takes Flight*; and *Captain Bob Sets Sail*. Roni Schotter lives in Hastings, New York.

GISELLE POTTER is the author and illustrator of *Chloë's Birthday . . . and Me* and *The Year I Didn't Go to School*. She is also the illustrator of Mary Pope Osborne's *Sleeping Bobby*, *The Brave Little Seamstress* (an ALA Notable Book), and *Kate and the Beanstalk* (also an ALA Notable Book). Ms. Potter is hoping someone like Selig will drop some good words on her head soon. She lives in Rosendale, New York.

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ISBN 0-375-83601-2

51695



9 780375 836015